MONTHLY UPDATE

West Africa: monthly update, September – October 2026

Edition of 2026-10-16 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

> *Developments reported in sources published between the beginning of last month and today, grouped by story, oldest first.*

PROGRESS

INSTITUTIONS AND MANDATES
Regional collaboration

INSTRUMENTS AND HARMONISATION
Data protection · AI

SHARED SYSTEMS AND INFRASTRUCTURE
Connectivity · Cybersecurity · Digital Identity and CRVS · Digital Payments and Fintech · Sectoral management information systems · National statistics

COORDINATION AND COLLABORATION
Innovation ecosystem

Institutions and mandates

Regional collaboration

COMMISSIONER FOR INFRASTRUCTURE, ENERGY AND DIGITALISATION

- **Amin Amidu Sulemani appointed ECOWAS Commissioner for Infrastructure, Energy and Digitalisation** — Adomonline.com, 15 September 2026

  Approved at the Abuja Assembly for the 2026-2030 term, under new Commission president Birame Diop.

WEST AFRICA YOUTH OBSERVERS NETWORK

- **ECOWAS urged to finalise regional AI election framework** — The Guardian Nigeria, 17 September 2026

  The communique of a youth democracy conference in Dakar urged ECOWAS to finalise and operationalise a regional framework for the use of artificial intelligence by election management bodies, citing deepfakes and disinformation as risks to electoral integrity. It also asks member states to invest in digital civic education and the bloc to use diplomatic channels against internet and social-media restrictions during elections, and endorses a youth election-observers network anchored to ECOWAS.

AES PLATFORM OF MEDIA AND COMMUNICATION REGULATORS (PAREMEC)

- **Souveraineté informationnelle dans l'espace AES : la Plateforme des Autorités de régulation des médias et de la communication portée sur les fonts baptismaux - CSC - BURKINA FASO** — Conseil supérieur de la communication (CSC), Burkina Faso, 21 September 2026 BURKINA FASO NIGER MALI

  Founding regulator's own account: CSC, HAC and ONC signed PAREMEC constitutive act, Niamey, 17-18 Sept 2026.

- **Forum de Bamako : la gouvernance numérique au cœur des priorités du Sahel** — La Gazette du Sahel, 13 October 2026 MALI

  HAC Mali seeks Meta talks on monetising Sahel content and national languages in algorithms; AES regulators' cooperation.

AES REGULATORS' COOPERATION CONVENTION AND CONSEIL DES RÉGULATEURS DU SAHEL

- **Coopération régionale entre les régulateurs de l'AES : Signature d'une convention de coopération le 25 septembre 2026 à Ouagadougou** — leFaso.net (communiqué of ARCEP Burkina Faso), 23 September 2026 BURKINA FASO MALI NIGER

  The telecoms regulators of Burkina Faso, Mali and Niger are to sign a cooperation agreement in Ouagadougou on 25 September creating a Sahel Regulators' Council. It covers roaming within the Alliance of Sahel States, consumer protection, cybersecurity, spectrum, mutual recognition of type-approved equipment and joint positions in international bodies.

- **Espace AES : Les régulateurs des télécommunications créent le Conseil des régulateurs du Sahel** — leFaso.net, 26 September 2026 BURKINA FASO MALI NIGER

  Burkina, Mali, Niger regulators sign convention: five priorities, free roaming, border spectrum, coordinated 5G.

MANO RIVER UNION INTERNET GOVERNANCE FORUM (MRU-IGF)

- **Hon. Mariama Bangura Calls for Stronger Digital Laws at MRU Internet Governance Forum 2026** — OWLPRESS, 23 September 2026 LIBERIA SIERRA LEONE GUINEA CÔTE D'IVOIRE

  3rd MRU-IGF, Paynesville, 21-22 Sep 2026; Sierra Leone MP urges harmonised data-protection and AI laws in four states.

WEST AFRICAN BACKBONE MANAGERS NETWORK (ROA-BN)

- **Souveraineté numérique : Les pays ouest-africains connectent leurs stratégies** — Le Soleil, 9 October 2026 SENEGAL

  Ten states meet in Dakar 8 Oct 2026; founding texts, 2026-2030 plan pending; aim to keep data transit in-region.

Instruments and harmonisation

Data protection

SEMINAR OF AFRICAN DATA-PROTECTION AUTHORITIES

- **Gouvernance des données : la CDP réunit plusieurs autorités africaines à Dakar** — Agence de Presse Sénégalaise, 7 September 2026 SENEGAL

  Four-day Dakar seminar of African and international data protection authorities, 7-10 September 2026.

AI

UEMOA REGIONAL ARTIFICIAL-INTELLIGENCE STRATEGY

- **Avis à manifestation d'intérêt N°0003-2026 — Élaboration d'une stratégie régionale de l'Intelligence Artificielle** — Commission de l'UEMOA, 6 September 2026

  Commission tenders a 90-day consultancy for the regional AI strategy; bids closed 2026-09-11, Ouagadougou.

- **Intelligence artificielle : l'UEMOA prepare une strategie regionale pour accelerer la transformation economique de l'Union** — Horonya Finance, 15 September 2026

  Draft regional AI strategy shown 2026-09-14; UEMOA states average 31.5/100 on AI readiness against a world 47.

- **Préparation à l'IA : Le Sénégal leader dans l'UEMOA, mais la région reste en deçà de la moyenne mondiale** — Seneweb, 15 September 2026 SENEGAL

  Senegal 1st of 8 UEMOA states on Oxford Insights 2025 AI readiness; draft regional AI strategy presented.

- **Union economique et monetaire ouest-africaine : des journalistes a l'ecole des enjeux et chantiers de l'integration sous regionale** — Sidwaya, 15 September 2026 BURKINA FASO

  WAEMU press session, Ouagadougou, September 2026; agenda names a regional AI strategy and the IMPACT 2030 plan.

- **L'UEMOA prepare une strategie regionale de l'intelligence artificielle pour 2027 face au retard technologique de la zone** — Abidjan.net News, 16 September 2026

  Bids for the costed AI action plan opened 2026-09-11; UEMOA strategy adoption programmed for 2027.

REGIONAL PARLIAMENTARY WORKSHOP ON REGULATING ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

- **Atelier régional sur l'IA : le Sénégal appelle à «anticiper les évolutions technologiques»** — PressAfrik, 16 September 2026 SENEGAL

  Dakar, 16-18 September 2026: regional workshop on AI regulation at Senegal's National Assembly.

ECONEC WEST AFRICA WORKING GROUP ON ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

- **ECOWAS: 'High cost of politics shutting out West African youths'** — The Nation Newspaper (Nigeria), 23 September 2026

  ECONEC sets up West Africa AI working group to draft election-body framework on deepfakes and disinformation.

ECONEC GUIDELINES ON ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE IN ELECTORAL PROCESSES

- **INEC moves to implement AI guidelines for elections** — Daily Trust, 14 October 2026 NIGERIA

  The ECOWAS Network of Electoral Commissions (ECONEC) has adopted guidelines on the use of AI in elections, validated at meetings on 12 and 13 October, its permanent secretary Serigne Mamadou Ka said during a visit to INEC in Abuja. The visit concerned implementing them across West African election bodies; the text has not been published.

Shared systems and infrastructure

Connectivity

ACE SUBMARINE CABLE CAPACITY UPGRADE

- **ACE Cable Selects Ciena for 30 Tb/s Upgrade** — Submarine Telecoms Forum, 21 September 2026

  The consortium behind the 17,000 km Africa Coast to Europe submarine cable has chosen Ciena's WaveLogic 6 Extreme optics to raise its total capacity above 30 Tb/s, Ciena said on 21 September 2026. The upgrade keeps the existing equipment at ACE's 18 landing stations, which serve more than 20 countries, and adds new transmission gear. No completion date was given.

Cybersecurity

CENTRAL BANK SUPERVISORY POSITION ON BANK CYBER-RISK

- **UEMOA : pres de 7 000 milliards FCFA de liquidites, mais la BCEAO appelle les banques a la vigilance** — Financial Afrik, 10 September 2026

  The West African central bank's monetary policy committee found the union's banking fundamentals sound - liquidity near FCFA 7,000 billion, credit growing and solvency above the regulatory norm - while calling on banks to stay vigilant against cyberattacks. No incident count or supervisory instrument accompanies the call.

BCEAO UNIFIED CYBERSECURITY INCIDENT DETECTION AND RESPONSE PLATFORM

- **Résultats de l'appel d'offres AO/Z00/DBA/054/2026 : plateforme unifiée de détection, d'analyse et de réponse aux incidents de cybersécurité à la BCEAO** — BCEAO, 7 October 2026

  Contract to Groupement Neurones Technologies; call open 19 March to 29 May 2026.

Digital Identity and CRVS

ENBIC (ECOWAS NATIONAL BIOMETRIC IDENTITY CARD)

- **Africa: How Ecowas Biometric Card Will Ease Travel for Member States' Citizens Across West Africa - Officials** — Premium Times (Abuja), via allAfrica.com, 17 September 2026 NIGERIA

  Officials said at a Lagos workshop that seven ECOWAS member states — Senegal, Guinea-Bissau, Ghana, Benin, The Gambia, Sierra Leone and Nigeria — have deployed the regional biometric identity card, which is intended to replace the handwritten regional travel certificate. The chip carries the issuing authority's digital signature over the stored identity data, so any alteration breaks the trust chain at border authentication; member states committed in April to work towards mutual acceptance at borders by December.

- **ECOWAS steps up citizen biometric identity push for seamless cross-border travel** — Tribune Online, 17 September 2026 NIGERIA

  At a Lagos workshop on the regional biometric identity card, Nigeria's immigration service said the card serves the same purpose as the regional passport within the subregion, is renewable every five years, costs N35,500 and is applied for online with a single physical visit for biometric capture. The ECOWAS Commission framed it as harmonising identification and addressing cross-border crime and irregular migration.

- **ECOWAS pushes biometric ID toward region-wide border acceptance by December** — Biometric Update, 5 October 2026 GHANA

  ECOWAS is running public campaigns in Ghana and Nigeria ahead of its December 2026 target for all member states to accept its biometric identity card at air, land and sea borders. Seven member states have issued the card so far.

Digital Payments and Fintech

UNION ELECTRONIC MONEY AND LARGE-MICROFINANCE POSITION

- **Monnaie électronique dans l'UEMOA – le Sénégal concentre 29,7 % des actifs et occupe la première place** — Digital Mag Côte d'Ivoire, 1 September 2026 SENEGAL

  Senegal 29.7% of WAEMU e-money and 26.5% of microfinance assets at end-2025; Wave holds near 80% at home.

MOBILE MONEY TRANSACTION VALUE ACROSS THE MONETARY UNION

- **UMOA : Les transactions mobiles atteignent 164.169 milliards de francs Cfa en 2025** — CADRECO, 7 September 2026

  FCFA 164,169bn in mobile transactions in 2025, up 31.4%, with electronic money institutions back in profit.

PI-SPI (UEMOA INTEROPERABLE INSTANT-PAYMENT PLATFORM)

- **Communiqué : Homologation des API Business de la Plateforme Interopérable du Système de Paiement Instantané (PI-SPI) de l'UEMOA** — BCEAO, 16 September 2026

  The BCEAO certified the business APIs of a first group of participants on the regional instant payment platform on 16 September 2026, letting firms send and receive payments, submit bulk settlements and track transactions across the monetary union whatever the other party's provider.

- **Liste des API Business PI-SPI homologuées par la BCEAO (septembre 2026)** — BCEAO, 16 September 2026

  The BCEAO's list of September 2026 names 23 participants whose business APIs are certified on the regional instant payment platform: nine in Senegal, seven in Côte d'Ivoire, two in Niger and one each in Benin, Burkina Faso, Guinea-Bissau, Mali and Togo.

- **Transactions de monnaie électronique entre personnes physiques par l'intermédiaire de la Plateforme Interopérable du Système de Paiement Instantané (PI-SPI) de l'UEMOA** — BCEAO, 2 October 2026

  From 2 Nov 2026: sends up to FCFA 8,000/day free, 0-0.8% above, receipt free; intra-WAEMU parity from 1 June 2027.

- **Connexion des Trésors Publics à la Plateforme Interopérable du Système de Paiement Instantané (PI-SPI) de l'Union Economique et Monétaire Ouest Africaine** — BCEAO, 8 October 2026 CÔTE D'IVOIRE

  Treasuries can pay salaries, grants and collect taxes on PI-SPI; Côte d'Ivoire's already runs bulk payments on it.

INSTITUTIONS CONNECTED TO PI-SPI

- **Liste des participants autorisés à ouvrir les services de PI-SPI au public - mise à jour du 30 septembre 2026** — BCEAO, 30 September 2026

  175 authorised as of 30 Sept 2026: Senegal 43, Côte d'Ivoire 38, Burkina Faso 20, Mali 19.

- **Wave rejoint la plateforme de paiement instantané de la BCEAO, un an après son lancement** — Agence Ecofin, 1 October 2026 SENEGAL

  On BCEAO list of 30 Sept 2026, authorised for Senegal; absent at Sept 2025 launch; 175 participants vs 45 at launch.

BCEAO ACCESSION TO THE PAN-AFRICAN PAYMENT AND SETTLEMENT SYSTEM

- **Troisième session ordinaire du Conseil des Ministres de l'Union au titre de l'année 2026** — BCEAO, 2 October 2026

  Dakar, 2 Oct 2026: opinion on BCEAO and UMOA banks joining PAPSS; procurement directive; social protection 2026-2035.

USERS CONNECTED TO PI-SPI

- **Transactions de monnaie électronique entre personnes physiques par l'intermédiaire de la Plateforme Interopérable du Système de Paiement Instantané (PI-SPI) de l'UEMOA** — BCEAO, 2 October 2026

  Summarised under Digital Payments and Fintech.

BCEAO CONNECTION OBLIGATION FOR INSTANT-PAYMENT PARTICIPANTS

- **BCEAO makes PI-SPI mandatory, revises its fees, and finally raises the question of new financial services linked to the platform** — Financial Afrik, 4 October 2026

  Youssaou Koanda: free P2P makes connection a compliance cost; only 24 API Business approvals; new-uses goal a first.

- **Wave Joins PI-SPI as BCEAO Rewrites Instant Payment Fee Rules** — Ecofin Agency, 5 October 2026

  Prior regime: receipt free for 30 operations a month, 1% cap beyond; Business APIs and 2025 e-money figures.

UEMOA ELECTRONIC-MONEY ISSUER INSTRUCTION (008-05-2015)

- **Instruction n° 020 portant modification de l'Instruction n° 008-05-2015 du 21 mai 2015 régissant les conditions et modalités d'exercice des activités des émetteurs de monnaie électronique dans les Etats membres de l'Union Monétaire Ouest Africaine (UMOA)** — BCEAO, 8 October 2026

  Caps from 2 Nov 2026: FCFA 4m held, FCFA 15m reloaded a month per client and issuer; 65% of float in demand deposits.

- **UMOA : la BCEAO double le plafond des avoirs en monnaie électronique à 4 millions de FCFA** — Financial Afrik, 9 October 2026

  The West African central bank doubled the ceiling on electronic money one client may hold at one issuer to FCFA 4 million and raised monthly reloads from FCFA 10 million to FCFA 15 million. Issuers may go beyond them only with its prior authorisation.

- **BCEAO to Double Mobile Money Account Limit to CFAF 4 Million** — Togo First, 12 October 2026

  The West African central bank's new instruction doubles the cap on electronic money one client may hold at one issuer to FCFA 4 million, from a limit set in 2015. Issuers must now keep at least 65% of their float in demand deposits, down from 75%.

Sectoral management information systems

DIGITAL MONITORING PLATFORM FOR THE CONTINENTAL DEMOGRAPHIC DIVIDEND ROADMAP

- **ECA and UNFPA to Convene a Regional Technical Validation and Operationalization of the Digital Monitoring Platform for the Implementation of the African Union Roadmap on Harnessing the Demographic Dividend in Africa** — United Nations Economic Commission for Africa (ECA), 2 September 2026

  Abidjan, 7-9 September 2026: eight West African pilot countries validate the AU demographic-dividend tool.

- **Dividende démographique : le Bénin et 7 pays ouest-africains harmonisent leurs données** — Fraternite, 8 September 2026 BENIN

  Benin among eight West African states piloting a demographic dividend monitoring platform, Abidjan 7-9 September 2026.

National statistics

ECOWAS PRACTICAL GUIDE FOR POPULATION AND HOUSING CENSUSES

- **Recensements généraux de la population et de l'habitat: L'Afrique de l'Ouest veut harmoniser ses méthodes** — La Nation, 16 September 2026 BENIN

  ECOWAS member states began validating a practical guide for population and housing censuses in Cotonou on 15 September 2026, meant to make West African census data more reliable and comparable across countries.

> ECOWAS LEADERSHIP AND STATISTICAL MANAGEMENT TRAINING FOR NATIONAL STATISTICAL SYSTEMS
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> - **Liberia: LISGIS Boss Cautions Against Inadequate Usage of AI for Data Collection** — FrontPage Africa, 6 October 2026 LIBERIA
>
>   A week-long ECOWAS training for managers of member states' national statistical systems opened in Monrovia on 5 October. The head of Liberia's statistics office said statisticians need training to use AI in data collection properly, and warned that it can harm the data as well as help.

Coordination and collaboration

Innovation ecosystem

> ECOWAS STARTUP AWARDS
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> - **ECOWAS Targets $5m in Startup Deals, Launches Regional Platform to Scale 60 West African Businesses** — MSME Africa, 24 September 2026
>
>   Abuja, 21-30 Sep 2026; 60 startups from 6,000+ applicants; $30k/$20k/$15k seed prizes; planned digital academy.

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